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**Unit : 4
Chapter :3
WILD SWANS AT COOLE**

Appreciation of "The Wild Swans at Coole"

"The Wild Swans at Coole" is a beautiful poem written by W.B. Yeats. The poem was written when the poet visited Coole Park after nineteen years. The main theme of the poem is the passage of time and the pain of growing old. The poet contrasts his aging self with the eternally young and beautiful swans. The poem expresses the sadness and loneliness that comes with old age.

The poem shows how everything changes with time except nature's beauty. The swans remain as beautiful and energetic as they were nineteen years ago. However, the poet has grown old and weak. His heart is "sore" when he looks at the brilliant creatures. The swans move in pairs, "unwearied" and full of passion. Their hearts have not grown old. The poet fears that one day he will wake up to find the swans have flown away. This represents his fear of losing all inspiration, youth, and vitality from his life. The autumn setting symbolizes the autumn of the poet's life.

Yeats uses several poetic devices to enhance the beauty of the poem. The rhyme scheme is ABCBDD in each stanza. He uses alliteration in lines like "The bell-beat of their wings" and "cold companionable streams." Imagery is used beautifully throughout the poem with descriptions like "trees in their autumn beauty" and "October twilight." The poem ends with a rhetorical question. The tone of the poem is melancholic. The lines I like most are "Their hearts have not grown old; / Passion or conquest, wander where they will, / Attend upon them still." These lines beautifully capture the timeless spirit of nature.

Comprehension Questions

1. What season is described in the poem?

The poem describes the autumn in the life of the poet.

2. How many swans does the poet see at Coole?

The poet sees fifty-nine swans.

3. How many years have passed since the poet's first visit?

Nineteen years have passed since the first visit.

4. What does autumn symbolise in the poem?

Autumn symbolises the onset of old age in the poet's life.

5. What happens when the poet tries to count the swans?

The swans suddenly fly away before he can finish counting.

6. Which line tells that the poet is in a sad state of mind?

"And now my heart is sore."

7. What does twilight represent in the poem?

Twilight represents the twilight of the poet's life.

8. 'Trod with a lighter tread'. What does this line signify?

He walked with a lighter tread during his first visit.

9. How do the swans move in the water?

The swans paddle in pairs, lover by lover.

10. Which line tells that the swans are in youthful spirits every time?

"The hearts of the swans have not grown old."

11. What qualities still attend upon the swans?

Passion and conquest still attend upon them.

12. How does the poet describe the swans on the water?

He describes them as mysterious and beautiful.

13. What does the poet fear will happen one day?

He fears he will wake up to find the swans have flown away.

14. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem?

The rhyme scheme is ABCBDD.

15. What does the water mirror in the first stanza?

The water mirrors a still sky.

16. How does the poet describe the swans' wings when they fly?

He describes them as clamorous wings.

17. What do the swans represent in the poem?

The swans represent eternal youth, beauty, and artistic inspiration.

18. What kind of life does the stillness point to?

The stillness points to a sedentary life.

19. What do the dry woodland paths symbolise?

They symbolise a dull and dreary life.

20. What will the swans continue to do for others?

They will continue to delight men's eyes.

21. What makes the poet's heart sore?

Seeing the unchanged beauty of the swans in contrast to his fading time makes his heart sore.

22. What aspect of the swans contrasts with the poet's condition?

Their youthful vigor contrasts with his aging condition.

Figures of speech

Visual images

- trees in their autumn beauty
- dry woodland paths
- October twilight

- the water / Mirrors a still sky

Auditory Images

clamorous wings,
bell-beat of their wings

Metaphor

- . bell-beat of their wings
- . water / Mirrors a still sky

Personification

- . Their hearts have not grown old
- . Passion or conquest...Attend upon them still

Symbolism

- trees in their autumn beauty
(representing the onset of old- age)
- twilight (indicating the fast approach of old age)
- swans [youth]

Contrast

- . The unchanging swans versus the changing, aging speaker
- . Past ("lighter tread") versus present ("heart is sore")
- . The swans' youthfulness versus the speaker's weariness

Alliteration

still sky
bell-beat
lover by lover
They paddle in the cold
Companionable streams or climb
Tread with lighter tread

Consonance

(repetition of consonant sounds in words, whose vowel sounds differ)

Eg:

- And scatter wheeling in great broken rings

. Upon their clamorous wings.

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 Rhetorical Question

- among what rushes will they build
- By what lake's edge or pool

Delight men's eyes when I awake some day To find they have flown away?

 Assonance

- . And scatter wheeling in great broken rings
- . Upon their clamorous wings

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